

MOST VOTERS IN THE STATE, PARTICULARLY THE POOR, SEEMED HAPPY WITH THE CONGRESS'S GUARANTEES. PER THE INDIA TODAY-AMI EXIT POLL, 10 PER CENT OF THOSE WHO VOTED THE CONGRESS CITED ITS WELFARE PROMISES AS THE REASON

make the war on corruption one of its main planks, especially as the Lokayukta unearthed another case in March 2023 in which BJP MLA K. Madalu Virupakshappa's son was caught allegedly accepting a bribe of Rs 40 lakh on his behalf. A series of innovative social media campaigns was unleashed to ensure that the image of the BJP running a corrupt government stuck.

Two backroom boys played a key role in devising and executing the Congress campaign narrative—the 41-year-old reclusive and bespectacled Sunil Kanugolu, the party's superbright election strategist, and Sasikanth Senthil, 44, an earnest-looking former IAS officer who took premature retirement and joined the party and was made the All India Congress Committee war room in-charge. Kanugolu and his team came up with the catchy 'PayCM' campaign, '40% commission sarkar' slogan and also helped convert the Nandini vs Amul row into a matter of Kannada pride. Senthil deployed multi-media teams to come up with "quirky yet effective messaging" that would make the campaign even more impactful. Explaining the strategy, Senthil says, "Narratives do not get into people's minds if you do not communicate them properly. So, it was not only quirky ideas but also organisational support. We got the leaders, the followers, everybody to pitch in. A huge amount of organisational syncing happened to make it work."

In another tactic, Surjewala told Congress leaders not to directly level corruption charges against the government but quote others who complained, be it the contractors' association, teachers or even a Lingayat seer who castigated the Bommai government for the malaise. "We disowned the 'PayCM' brand midway and made the common man the owner," he explains. "That's what makes for ideal communication. When people own it, rather than the party." They even extended covert support to the hundreds of students protesting a scam in the recruitment for sub-inspector posts in Bengaluru, ensuring that no Congress flag was waved at Freedom Park where the protesters were sitting on a dharna. Accusations of multiple scams against the Bommai government in the past two years only made the Congress's job easier, with the party highlighting each example in telling detail.

LESSON 3: NAIL THE ANTI-INCUMBENCY ADVANTAGE

Pradeep Gupta, founder of Axis My India (AMI), whose exit poll in collaboration with INDIA TODAY accurately predicted the results in Karnataka, outlines three main factors that determine the outcome in any election: *vaade* (promises), *daave* (claims) and *iraade* (intentions). *Daave*, says Gupta, are the claims the incumbent government makes about its performance and achievements, while *vaade* are the promises the challenger makes for better governance and new programmes. Based on the confidence levels the voters have either in the incumbent's achievements or in the opposition's promises, they express their intentions on the ballot paper. Gupta believes that for any ruling party to get re-elected, it needs to ensure that its performance remains above the the anti-incumbency threshold. With the BJP replacing its chief minister midstream, that very messaging weakened and governance began to falter.

That's when the Congress moved in for the kill. Feedback from internal surveys alerted the party to the fact that the voters, particularly those in the lower income groups and from scheduled castes and tribes, were hurting because of high prices and lack of steady income. So, in October 2022, when Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY) entered Karnataka, the Congress leader was told to focus only on local concerns, especially discrimination against the poor. The yatra's assertions against inflation, unemployment, wealth disparity and the politics of hate, thus, dovetailed neatly with the Congress campaign within the state, helping the party win 16 of the 21 constituencies that BJY transited through.

The Congress believes the BJY campaign further eroded the credibility of the Bommai government and its handling of